cricketer may not be allowed to play a variety of sports because of the danger of being injured in, say, schools rugby.

They specialize too early, and consequently lack the balance of someone who develops other skills in other sports, such as athleticism or physical resilience. They are shielded from everyday life. A boy who knows only cricket has a problem, because he hasn't been given the environment to become a well-rounded human being. There is more to life than being a slave to the MCC coaching manual.

I left St Paul's at the age of thirteen, having won a music scholarship to Bedford School. Andy Pick, Richard Bates and Derek Randall coached me at Bedford, but rarely analysed my technique with the intention of making fundamental changes. A development session with Essex led to the observation that I needed to make my eyes level on addressing the ball, but I didn't really have too much technical input until I was eighteen.

My attitude was a far more powerful formative influence. I was fifteen when Jeremy Farrell, the master in charge of cricket at Bedford, challenged me to become fitter and stronger by joining preschool swimming sessions with the staff. He felt I was too weak to consistently hit the ball square.

Though I could just about tolerate swimming if I wore goggles, I honestly loathed it. The first morning I turned up at the pool Jeremy Farrell and Barry Burgess, the rugby master, ordered me to swim for twenty minutes. I could barely do twenty-five metres, yet my competitive streak kicked in. Within three months I was quicker than my cricket teacher. It took me six months to overhaul the rugby master, but ultimately, I was flying past the pair of them.

I was obsessively single-minded. I swam twice a week and went out running with the boarding-house dog before breakfast. Derek Randall, a World Cup finalist as a player and a world-class eccentric, got up early to work with me on the bowling machine. The 7.45 a.m. alarm call on down days was a luxury because of the principles which had been unconsciously instilled in me at choir school, where I had to be up by seven each morning and have the time-management skills to juggle twenty-four hours' music a week around normal academic work.

Although I was studying music at Bedford, the St Paul's choir master had read me well. His final report concluded that he expected to hear more from me as a cricketer than a singer in the years to come. I enjoyed my musicality, and particularly loved singing Handel's 'Zadok the Priest',